Anglo-Saxon armour, weapons, and clothing
By the 11th century, warriors across northern Europe all wore similar chainmail. Anglo-Saxon swords were the weapons of wealthy warriors.



THE FRANKS

The Franks were a Germanic people who made a kingdom in Gaul after the fall of the Roman Empire in the west. During the reign of their greatest king, Charlemagne (ruled 771–814), the Franks conquered an empire that covered most of Christian western Europe, fighting Saxons, Danes, Muslims, and Avars in annual military campaigns around the borders of their lands.

The majority of the Frankish army of the 8th and 9th centuries was made up of levies. All free men who were judged to be sufficiently well-off to afford armour and a weapon had to present themselves for military service, led by their local count, whenever the king required. More important than these part-time soldiers were the trained warriors who formed the heavy cavalry. These consisted of the king's household troops and of the followers of nobles, who held their high position in the realm in return for military service. These aristocrats would be ordered to turn up at a certain time and place not only with a retinue of fully equipped horsemen but also with a supply train of carts carrying food and other necessities for three months' campaigning.

The Frankish cavalry wore the "byrnie", or mail coat, and carried shields. Their principal weapons were the lance or spear and the sword. According to Charlemagne's edicts the horsemen were also expected to be equipped with a bow. At the famous battle of Poitiers against Arab raiders in 732 the Franks fought on foot, but by Charlemagne's time they fought mounted, using stirrups and the high-backed saddle to provide a sufficiently stable platform for wielding their weapons. With this style of fighting they presaged the knight of the high Middle Ages.

Frankish cavalry
The charge with lance couchant – held horizontally as in a joust – was one way that the Frankish cavalryman fought; he also wielded the weapon overarm, using a stabbing motion.

